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NewStuff

PDA Phone

Sprint PCS has introduced the TP3000 Touchpoint Phone. This single-band phone features a personal digital assistant with graphical interface and built-in stylus. The TP3000 offers voice-activated dialing, one-touch access to the wireless Web, and one-touch speakerphone access. Its battery provides approximately 3 hours of talk time.
Suggested price: $399.99; monthly service fees from $19.99. Additional information: www.sprintpcs.com

Short-Range Wireless Modem

RCA calls its WMJ900 high-speed, digital wireless modem "the Shark." The modem allows consumers to set up their PCs or laptops anywhere in the home and still have Internet access. The WMJ900 consists of two transceiver units: a base and an extension. The base unit connects to the phone line, while the extension unit connects to a PC or laptop to provide an invisible connection for up to 300 feet.
Suggested price: $249.95. Additional information: www.rca.com

The Philadelphia Inquirer

Technology in Brief

Intel predicts chips that are 20 times faster by 2010

■ Intel Corp. said this week that it expects chip-makers to build devices that are 20 times faster than today's by 2010, although the power needed to run those processors could slow advancements. Chips will run at 20 to 30 gigahertz, using a billion transistors to handle a trillion operations a second, Intel vice president Patrick Gelsinger said. Today's best Pentium 4 runs at 1.5 GHz. The faster speeds would make hefty computing tasks such as speech recognition and gesture commands not only possible but pervasive, and suggest uses of which engineers have only dreamed. The speeds also present a big problem, the world's biggest maker of computer chips said. Those devices would consume so much power, given current designs, that manufacturers need to start developing new techniques now to cut back power consumption. "More than any other, we see power as becoming a limitation to future growth," Gelsinger said. "We see [chips] well in excess of a billion transistors — to do so without delivering any nuclear reactors, we're going to have to address this limitation in a meaningful way." As chip-makers boost the speed of processors, the power needs grow exponentially. The predicted consumption is "prohibitively large for any practical applications," Gelsinger said. The high-level devices that Intel is predicting would equate to today's fastest computer — with more than 500 processors inside it — on a single chip. At a speed of 30 GHz, 30 billion electrical pulses move through a chip each second. The more pulses, the faster a chip performs tasks in a computer.

Cornell seeks computer users for Backyard Bird Count

■ The Cornell University Laboratory of Ornithology is asking computer users to log on to its BirdSource Web site, at www.birdsource.org, for the fourth annual Great Backyard Bird Count. "We're asking everyone, everywhere in North America, to take a few minutes and tell us what birds they see" between Feb. 16 and 19, said John Fitzpatrick, director of the lab.

Nortel technology allows ISPs to track users' movements

■ Nortel Networks Corp. said that its new technology for Internet service providers enables them to secretly track customers' online movements, but that the ISPs would be unwise to do so. Nortel's Personal Internet technology suite, introduced late last month, allows Internet providers to temporarily increase the bandwidth allotted customers. The feature would allow Web surfers to watch a movie or listen to music, for example, without paying significantly higher access fees. But the Personal Technology suite quickly raised the hackles of privacy advocates, who contended that it enables ISPs to track the Web-surfing habits of each customer and resell the information to advertisers or other third parties. "This is a disturbing development, to find a supplier of Internet infrastructure touting its surveillance capabilities," said Jason Catlett, president of Junkbusters, a privacy group. A Nortel spokesman acknowledged that the technology does allow that capability. "Will it link surfing data with who you are? Yes, but that can be shut down at the ISP," David Chamberlin of Nortel said. Chamberlin said customers could dictate their individual preferences to the ISP, allowing them to receive advertising targeted to their interests or prohibiting the ISP from sharing the data.

Sony has strained relationships with PlayStation 2's launch

■ Sony Corp.'s troubled launch of its flagship game console, PlayStation 2, has strained its relationships with some key allies — the software publishers that once helped it claim the top spot in a $20 billion-a-year market. Analysts say that while Sony will be a leading contender in the market for the new generation of consoles, its stickier relationships with some U.S. game developers have cast some doubt on its market dominance and could open the door for rivals. "In development ease and lead time, Sony has been more difficult to work with this time around than for the original PlayStation launch," Miguel Iribarren, an analyst at Wedbush Morgan Securities, said. One reason that Sony was able to break into a market dominated by Nintendo Co. Ltd. and Sega Corp. when it launched the PlayStation in 1995 was that it lured third-party game developers to produce top games for an unproved platform. But now that the PlayStation is the world's most popular console, some game developers say Sony has neglected them. Molly Smith, a spokeswoman for Sony Computer Entertainment America, said that the record number of titles ready at the launch of PlayStation 2 was a testament to developers' support. She said shipment delays for the console were regrettable, but added that the production problems had been fixed. Sony launched PlayStation 2 in the United States in October, but the company is expected to face stiff competition later in the year from Nintendo's GameCube and handheld Game Boy Advance, plus Microsoft Corp.'s market entry with the Xbox.

IBM to spend $300 million on Linux support services

■ International Business Machines Corp. said it would spend $300 million to create consulting practices to advise corporations on the free Linux computer-operating system. IBM had been giving advice to clients and working with Linux distributors Red Hat Inc. and Linuxcare Inc. to provide technical support. Now, IBM's Global Services unit will create specific Linux consulting practices and broaden its technical-support alliances to include Germany's SuSE Linux AG, IBM vice president Irving Wladawsky-Berger said. IBM is seeking to prove Linux's reliability, and it hopes to sell more hardware, software and services in the process, at the expense of competitors such as server-computer-maker Sun Microsystems Inc., which uses a proprietary operating system. IBM also argues that the open operating system is needed to allow any device to work with any other device in the Internet-connected world.

IBM says it has built fastest hard drive for corporate servers

■ International Business Machines Corp. said it built the fastest hard-disk drive for corporate server computers to compete with market leader Seagate Technology L.L.C. Since early last year, Seagate has been the lone maker of drives that turn at a speed of 15,000 revolutions per minute. The standard has been 10,000 r.p.m. IBM's drive also runs at 15,000 r.p.m. and improves other operations to surpass Seagate in the time needed to retrieve data, said Bill Healy, vice president for IBM's storage technology division.

College students prefer electronic books in publisher's survey

■ Versaware Inc., an electronic and Internet publisher, said that 62 percent of college students it surveyed said they would prefer electronic textbooks over new print textbooks. The company said 87 percent of the students surveyed said they believed that e-textbooks could be more interesting that print volumes. For the survey, Versaware interviewed students from 63 colleges in 22 states. Based in New York City, Versaware offers an e-book platform that textbook publishers use to enable students to download Versaware eTexts to their computer hard drives.

Web has solid resources on black history

Online, teachers can find information that includes biographies, interactive quizzes, letters and narratives.

Joyce Kasman Valenza
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> *"We should emphasize not Negro History, but the Negro in history. What we need is not a history of selected races or nations, but the history of the world void of national bias, race hate, and religious prejudice."*
> — *Carter Woodson, on founding Negro History Week, 1926*

Carter Woodson's dream won't be fully realized until all our textbooks and classrooms examine history holistically, multidimensionally, and with room for individual exploration.

I asked a scholar and a student why Black History Month remains important 75 years after its founding.

The scholar is Mary J. Osirim, associate professor of sociology and chair and codirector of the Center for Ethnicities, Communities and Social Policy at Bryn Mawr College. For her, the celebration remains valid for two reasons.

"First, it reminds us all of the outstanding accomplishments of the many historical figures of African descent in the U.S. as well as of the achievements of the many average black citizens who have persisted here in the face of great odds," Osirim said. "This history is not only important for African Americans, but for all who live in this country. It is not just 'Black History' but 'American history.'

"Black History Month is also important symbolically because it suggests that our nation is culturally diverse," Osirim said. "... By the year 2050, populations of color will constitute the majority of the U.S. population. ... Today, Black History Month further encourages us to recognize the many challenges that remain in weaving these many different cultural threads into one American fabric."

Melanie Chavarria, 16, a Springfield Township High School student, enjoys reading about black history. But she also recognizes that "there's a bigger picture. Our history is not in the textbooks in the same way as the Revolutionary War," said Chavarria. "And it might be a history that most people don't want to face. ... Other cultures and histories should be celebrated. I want to make sure what happened before doesn't happen again."

The Web can help us reach beyond our textbooks to create an awareness of our diversity and a deeper understanding of what happened before. Here are a few solid resources to explore with students.

The reference publishers have transferred a generous chunk of their material online. Encyclopedia Britannica's Guide to Black History, http://blackhistory.eb.com/, is updated and redesigned. The Britannica spotlight offers a rich archive of 600 articles and related media, selected links, and a teacher's guide to support its six thoughtful student activities.

Gale Group's Celebrating Black History pulls together a collection of biographies from Gale's suite of biographical reference sources, a quiz question for each day of the month, a 400-year timeline, 12 activities, and a collection of links. It is at www.gale.com/freresrc/blkhstry/index.htm.

Infoplease.com offers an impressive new collection of resources — biographies of notable African Americans in all areas of achievement, relevant statistics, a civil rights timeline, interactive quizzes, and a crossword puzzle. Special features explore Negro League baseball, icing the stereotypes (black hockey players), African American literature, blacks in the military, and a not-to-be-missed collection of African American quotations. It is at www.infoplease.com/spot/bhm1.html.

World Book's comprehensive Special Report, the African American Journey, at www.worldbook.com/fun/aajourny/html/, pulls articles from the encyclopedia and covers African American history from the slave trade through the modern civil rights movement. A slide show follows African Americans from slavery to freedom. Students will be interested in reading our early presidents' thoughts about slavery.

The Social Studies School Service offers an assortment of quality resources to buy to support Black History Month. Scroll to the bottom of the page and you'll discover free sample activities from books, an exceptional collection of annotated links, and 20 lesson plans designed to inspire critical thinking. The site is at www.socialstudies.com/c/@NEGSWNReBsRmk/Pages/blackhistory.html.

Black History: Exploring African American History on the Web, www.kn.pacbell.com/wired/BHM AfroAm.html, features six Web-based activities. The Hotlist is an impressive collection of categorized links to explore, the Treasure Hunt is an interactive quiz in which students are guided by selected links, and Sampling African America allows students to choose an area of study directed by open-ended questions. Little Rock 9, Integration 0, is a role-playing WebQuest that asks students to explore "What, if anything, should be done to racially desegregate U.S. schools?" The Tuskegee Tragedy WebQuest asks students to draw connections between this study and such topics as abortion, gun control, and concentration camp experiments.

For those who use primary sources in the classroom, the Library of Congress offers several exhibits relating to black history. The African American Odyssey, http://memory.loc.gov/ammem/aaohtml/aohome.html, "tells the story of the African American quest for equality from the early national period to the twentieth century," using government documents, manuscripts, maps, and musical scores. The Daniel A. P. Murray Pamphlet Collection — at http://lcweb2.loc.gov/ammem/aap/aaphome.html — presents a unique view of African American history and culture through its pamphlets, sermons, slave narratives, speeches, and playbills produced between 1818 and 1907.

> **The Web can help us create an awareness of our diversity and a deeper understanding of history.**

The University of Virginia maintains an electronic archive of American slave narratives, at http://xroads.virginia.edu/~HYPER/wpa/wpahome.html. These first-hand accounts were gathered from more than 2,300 former slaves who were interviewed by writers of the Works Progress Administration between 1936 and 1938.

Black History, American History, at www.theatlantic.com/unbound/flashbks/black/blahisin.htm, archives seminal writings submitted by notable African Americans. It is presented by Atlantic Monthly. The works, perfect for study by high school students, include the Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King's "Letter from a Birmingham Jail," Frederick Douglass on "Reconstruction," and Booker T. Washington's "The Awakening of the Negro."

And if you just want the facts, Black Facts Online provides an online searchable database of events, birthdates and anniversaries that reveals what happened on any particular day in African American history. It is at http://blackfacts.com/.

Afro-America@The Black History Museum, www.afroam.org/history/history.html, hosts a variety of interactive exhibits. They include information on black resistance to slavery; black American troops during World War II; the Tuskegee Airmen; Jackie Robinson; the Black Panther Party; and advertisements of the '20s and '30s that encouraged black America "to undo its Blackness by concentrating on making itself as White as it could be." While you're there, check out the Kids Zone, which features a colorful assortment of puzzles, games, myths and fables.

Finally, if you are looking for a gateway to the study of African American history, you can find an almost overwhelming array of links to resources and lesson plans at the K-12 TLC Guide to African American Studies. It's at http://tlc.ai.org/hisafram.htm#GEN. The Family Education Network's Celebrating Black History portal, at www.familyeducation.com/topic/front/0,1156,1-4818,00.html, leads to resources, quizzes, discussion boards, and downloadable software. Provocative articles for parents include "Why Are All the Black Kids Sitting Together in the Cafeteria?"

Yahooligans also provides gateways with its Big Picture: Black History Month, at http://dailynews.yahoo.com/fc/Yahooligans/bhm and Yahooligans Black History, at www.yahooligans.com/Around_the_World/Countries/United_States/Cultures/African_American/History/.

About.com, at http://7-12educators.about.com/education/7-12educators/?once=true&, features an extensive directory of links in the areas of African origins, the civil rights movement, and the contributions of African Americans.

For a greater array of clickable links, visit my site at http://mciu.org/~spjvweb/inqlinks.html.

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